

Why Must There Be an Ideal of Beauty?

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Abstract

The ideal of beauty in §17 of Kant's *Critique of the Power of Judgment* is puzzling. Kant seems to think that there must be such an ideal, but it is difficult to see why this is. Moreover, Kant seems to describe the ideal as providing a standard in accordance with which we make certain judgments of beauty. As such, it is difficult to see how the ideal of beauty is not a *rule* for beauty, something the possibility of which Kant explicitly denies. As Rachel Zuckert puts it, it is not clear "why Kant suddenly introduces (and argues that we 'must have') a fixed, conceptually determined standard even for one kind of beauty (that of human beings), when the main tenor of his aesthetics is that there are no rules for beauty."

In this paper I attempt to clarify the role of the ideal of beauty in §17 of the *Critique of the Power of Judgment*. I argue that the ideal is introduced in order to explain the possibility of unanimous judgments of beauty with regard to certain objects of taste, and that its inclusion in the third *Critique* does not contradict "the main tenor of his aesthetics" because it is not a *rule* of beauty, but rather a *model* thereof.

1 Introduction

At the end of the Third Moment in the Analytic of the Beautiful of his *Critique of the Power of Judgment*, Kant discusses the "ideal of beauty" as something "which everyone must produce in himself," later saying that the ideal is "something we strive to produce in ourselves even if we are not in possession of it."^{1,2} Further, Kant thinks that the "human being alone is capable of an ideal of beauty..." such that "an ideal of beautiful flowers, of beautiful furnishings, of a beautiful view,

¹All quotes from Kant are from the *Cambridge Edition of the Works of Immanuel Kant* and will be cited using the standard Akademie pagination.

²KU 5:232.

cannot be conceived.”³ Despite this, the ideal of beauty is something “in accordance with which someone must judge everything that is an object of taste.”⁴ That is, we make use of the ideal of *human* beauty, a kind of representation of a maximally beautiful human being, when judging everything that is an object of taste. These are puzzling remarks, but despite that, the ideal remains somewhat unappreciated and inadequately discussed in the literature on the third *Critique*.⁵ Rachel Zuckert puts one of the issues facing the ideal of beauty this way:

It is rather hard to understand...why Kant suddenly introduces (and argues that we “must have”) a fixed, conceptually determined standard even for one kind of beauty (that of human beings), when the main tenor of his aesthetics is that there are no rules for beauty.⁶

Why does Kant introduce an ideal of beauty at all, and how does this thing not amount to his introduction of a rule through which we can determine the

³KU 5:233.

⁴KU 5:232.

⁵Henry Allison, for instance, writes the following on the ideal:

...from the standpoint of Kant’s theory of taste, [§17], which is concerned with the human figure as the ideal of beauty, does not add anything of decisive significance. From that standpoint, the beauty of a human being is simply another type of adherent beauty. The difference is that unlike the other forms of adherent beauty discussed in §16, that to which the beauty of the human figure adhere is the rational ideal of morality...and this is what makes it impermissible, rather than, as with the other types of adherent beauty, merely psychologically difficult, to view the beauty of the human figure apart from the concept of “what sort of thing it is meant to be.”...Kant’s discussion of this unique ideal points ahead to the connection of taste and the experience of beauty with morality...but it does not really contribute anything further to the theory of taste itself. (143)

Allison thus seems to see the discussion of the ideal in §17 as focused on explaining human beauty and as gesturing toward Kant’s view, developed in §59, that beauty is a symbol of morality (see *KU* 5:351-354), but as otherwise not adding anything interesting to the theory of taste more generally, and as such does not give it further consideration. Paul Guyer sees the ideal as playing a role in putting constraints on what we can find beautiful: he writes that “in §17, Kant offers an argument the point of which is obscure, but which may be regarded as one last attempt to provide some constraints on the proper objects of taste in spite of the absence of any determinate rules of beauty.” (225) The entire discussion, however, takes up about a page and a half of the text, and is based on a reading that strikes me as mistaken at points. (See Guyer, 225-226; for my objection to Guyer, see note 12.) Rachel Zuckert, in her 2005 paper “Boring Beauty and Universal Morality: Kant on the Ideal of Beauty” writes that “these arguments [Kant makes in his discussion of the ideal of beauty], and their place within Kant’s aesthetic theory, generate a number of philosophical and interpretive questions that I shall only slightly address here.” (114) The ideal receives no more attention in her 2007 book *Kant on Beauty and Biology: An Interpretation of the Critique of Judgment*, where she says of the ideal that it is “a complicated notion that I cannot discuss here.” (316)

⁶Rachel Zuckert, “Boring Beauty and Universal Morality: Kant on the Ideal of Beauty,” *Inquiry* 48, no. 2 (2005): 127.

beauty of objects? How does this not contradict the "main tenor of his aesthetics," as Zuckert puts it, according to which it is impossible for there to be anything like a rule in accordance with which we can judge objects to be beautiful? After all, if Kant thinks that the ideal provides the standard in accordance with which we make these sorts of judgments generally, then it's hard not to see him as thinking the ideal serves as a rule of beauty, at least in some way or another.

My goal in this paper is to try to flesh out Kant's understanding of the ideal of beauty, as well as its role in his overall aesthetic theory, by addressing these issues I've mentioned above. First, I'll discuss why Kant includes a section on the ideal of beauty in the third *Critique* at all and argue that the ideal is introduced in order to show how it is possible for there to be communicability and unanimity of judgments of taste in certain objects, even across different times and places. Second, I'll argue that the ideal does not constitute a *rule* in accordance with which we make judgments of beauty, but rather it is a *model* of beauty, and as such, the inclusion of the ideal does not contradict Kant's view that there can be no rules for the determination of beauty.

2 Unanimity and the Ideal of Beauty

First, to show why the ideal of beauty is introduced, we need to consider the text of the third *Critique*, and in particular, the first two paragraphs of §17.

Kant begins §17 by noting that "there can be no objective rule of taste that would determine what is beautiful through concepts," a view with which we are familiar at this point in the text and, moreover, stokes fears that inclusion of the ideal contradicts the overall tone of his aesthetics.⁷ He then goes on to note the reasons why no such rule of taste can exist, again covering old ground, noting that "to seek a principle of taste that would provide the universal criterion of the beautiful through concepts is a fruitless undertaking, because what is sought is impossible and intrinsically self-contradictory."⁸ In the middle of the first paragraph, though, Kant appears to shift topics when he writes the following:

The universal communicability of the sensation (of satisfaction or dissatisfaction), and indeed one that occurs without concepts, the unanimity, so far as possible, of all times and peoples about this feeling in the representation of certain objects: although weak and hardly sufficient for conjecture, this is the empirical criterion of the derivation of a taste, confirmed by examples, from the common ground, deeply

⁷KU 5:231.

⁸KU 5:231.

buried in all human beings, of unanimity in the judging of forms under which objects are given to them.⁹

Here is the thought as I understand it. Kant is noticing that, despite the fact that we engage in judgments of beauty at different times and places, it is nonetheless possible for these judgments to be communicated or otherwise shared. In fact, there may be certain objects in which the judgment of beauty (or lack thereof) and the accompanying feeling of pleasure is, in fact, universal. This seems to imply, then, that there is some "common ground" that we share, that is, something common to all human beings, which allows us to non-accidentally feel the same pleasure in these objects.

Now, what could this common ground be? The way Kant has set up the issue rules out the possibility of saying something like "the common ground is a shared social context" or something like that, since he appears to be thinking that we can make the same judgments of beauty without a shared social context; that is, he is already assuming "the unanimity, so far as possible, of all times and peoples about this feeling in the representation of certain objects." We also know, given what he says at the beginning of §17, that this common ground *cannot* be a rule of taste that human beings share, since there are no rules of taste in the first place, and as such there can be no shared rules either.

This, then, is the question to be answered in §17: what is the common, non-rule based ground which makes possible unanimous judgments of beauty?

At the beginning of the next paragraph, Kant concludes that "some products of taste are regarded as **exemplary** - not as if taste could be acquired by imitating others."¹⁰ I read Kant as saying the following: for it to be possible for us to take pleasure in the same objects, we must regard certain, as-of-yet-unknown products of taste as the examples or standards by which we judge other objects of taste. We cannot, as it were, think of taste as something that is "acquired by imitating others," or has its objects simply due to the influence of social factors, or whatever else. The reason, it seems to me, is that I will not feel pleasure in the right sort of way if I am simply judging an object on the basis of what someone tells me or by imitating another's judgments of taste; rather, I have to judge the object for *myself*.¹¹ I need to find the object beautiful for myself if I am to take pleasure in it,

⁹KU 5:231-232.

¹⁰KU 5:232.

¹¹Compare with KU 5:215-216: "If one judges objects merely in accordance with concepts, then all representation of beauty is lost. Thus there can also be no rule in accordance with which someone could be compelled to acknowledge something as beautiful. Whether a garment, a house, a flower is beautiful: no one allows himself to be talked into his judgment about that by means of any grounds or fundamental principles. One wants to submit the object to his own eyes, just as if his satisfaction depended on sensation..."

and imitation won't do that sort of work. (For instance, a movie critic can extol the virtues of a four hour long European film on the process by which paint dries as much as he likes and it will not convince me that it is a good movie, and I can't simply *make* myself find the movie beautiful by listening to the critic a lot.) But this sort of claim holds for everyone; that is, it must be the case that if anyone else finds pleasure in a beautiful object, he too must be judging the object for himself in some way, rather than engaging in imitation, and so must be judging the object by appeal to some standard that is not the product of mere imitation.

What, though, can serve as this standard? We know that there cannot be any rule for determining whether an object is beautiful; this is something Kant stated outright in the beginning of §17. In response to this question, Kant writes the following, somewhat puzzling passage which I provide in full:

From this, however, it follows that the highest model, the archetype of taste, is a mere idea, which everyone must produce in himself, and in accordance with which he must judge everything that is an object of taste, or that is an example of judging through taste, even the taste of everyone. **Idea** signifies, strictly speaking, a concept of reason, and **ideal** the representation of an individual being as adequate to an idea. Hence the archetype of taste, which indeed rests on reason's indeterminate idea of a maximum, but cannot be represented through concepts, would better be called the ideal of the beautiful, something that we strive to produce in ourselves even if we are not already in possession of it. But it will be merely an ideal of the imagination, precisely because it does not rest on concepts but on presentation, and the faculty of presentation is the imagination.¹²

Here is what I take the thought here to amount to. We saw above that Kant thinks we have to regard some products of taste as exemplary; that is, we have to regard some products of taste as being the kinds of things which serve as examples of truly beautiful objects. Further, these examples have to be things that I do not acquire simply by imitation or, more generally, through what you might call "external imposition," since otherwise there is no guarantee that I will feel pleasure in the right sort of way when making judgments of beauty with respect to these examples.¹³ It must be the case, then, that the standard of beauty

¹²KU 5:232.

¹³On my reading, then, the "exemplary product of taste" is the ideal of beauty. Kant earlier says "products" in the plural because he is speaking generally; he is only saying that there is something or things which serve as the examples of beauty and in accordance with which we make other judgments of beauty. Thus I disagree with Guyer, who thinks that the exemplary products of taste are those objects we empirically find to be especially beautiful: he writes that "...only the 'universal

in accordance with which we make our other judgments of beauty is a (mere) idea, that is, something which is not to be found in experience. For if the thing serving as the standard for beauty were found through experience, that is, empirically, then the kinds of judgments of beauty under consideration would have an imitative character, since I would be making a judgment of beauty in accordance with a standard that I ultimately had to acquire from some external source. The standard, then, must rather be a mere idea, something not found within experience, but instead something that "I must produce in myself" in order for these judgments of beauty to be possible in the first place.¹⁴ The standard of beauty is that of a maximally beautiful thing, something that we do not find in experience but instead makes a certain kind of aesthetic judgment possible in the first place. Further, Kant thinks that this archetype of taste is not, strictly speaking, an idea but rather an ideal. Ideas, according to Kant, are concepts of reason for which no intuition is adequate. Ideals, on the other hand, are individual representations of things which are taken to be adequate to the idea, even though, strictly speaking, they are not. The ideal of beauty, then, is the individual representation of a thing that is maximally beautiful, something that could be adequate to the idea of beauty even though it is not, but is something that we must nevertheless "strive to produce in ourselves even if we are not in possession of it," as it serves as the condition under which certain judgments of beauty, and the universal communicability of pleasure or displeasure in certain objects, is possible.

Why is it, though, that the ideal makes possible these unanimous judgments of beauty? Answering this question involves discussing more deeply the account offered by Kant, starting in paragraph 3 of §17, of the way in which the ideal is produced, something I will only briefly allude to here. In short, the ideal of beauty is composed of two things: first, the "aesthetic normal idea," which is a kind of singular representation of the average human being in a particular social setting; second, the "idea of reason," by which Kant means the idea of the morally good. Since we all share the idea of the morally good, its inclusion in the ideal of beauty, on Kant's view, helps make possible these unanimous judgments of beauty that Kant was seeking to explain.

communicability of the sensation (of delight or displeasure)' can provide any criterion for taste; and only objects which have actually been found —empirically—to provide or at least approximate to such a shared pleasure can be regarded as proper objects of taste. These objects are called 'exemplary' or 'models of taste...' (225).

¹⁴Thus when Kant says that the archetype of beauty must be produced in myself, he means two things: the archetype of beauty, i.e., the ideal of beauty, cannot be acquired passively but must be produced as the result of my activity, and that the archetype of beauty is the kind of thing that human beings, as a whole, necessarily produce in themselves (since otherwise the agreement and universal communicability, across time and place, that some objects are beautiful would not be possible, or if it were, any such agreement would be merely contingent).

So at this point, then, we know what the ideal of beauty is: it is an individual representation of a maximally beautiful object and serves as a kind of standard of beauty we must produce in ourselves in order for agreement in judgments of beauty (in at least some cases) to be possible. This, then, completes the first section of the paper, the goal of which, as I mentioned above, was to provide a more in-depth account of what Kant is up to in introducing the ideal of beauty. Kant's goal, on my reading, is to show what kind of thing can account for or explain how it is that we can judge of the same object that it is beautiful across different times and places. The ideal of beauty is what does this work since it includes ideas of morality which are common to all human beings across times and places.

3 Rules and Models

So far, then, I've argued that the ideal is introduced in order to show how unanimity in certain judgments of beauty is possible. There still seems to be a tension here, though, since the ideal seems to be a kind of *rule* for the judgment of beauty, which would contradict, as Zuckert put it, the "main tenor of this aesthetics."

The ideal, however, does not constitute a *rule* for determining what objects are beautiful. Rather, it is a *model* of beautiful objects.

First, there are textual reasons for thinking that Kant does not view rules and models as being the same thing. We've seen that Kant himself does not describe the ideal as a rule in §17 of the *KU*: he calls it "the highest model" and "the archetype of taste."¹⁵ Further, the contrast between rules and taste seems to be consistent: for instance, Kant says in the Vienna Logic that

Fine arts are arts that occur, not according to logical rules, but through empirical attempts. For only the effect distinguishes the rules of sensibility, which recognizes no rule of the understanding, and on this account, too, we have no rules of taste. Aesthetics cannot be a canon, then; rather, the attempts of the fine arts always precede, and then the rules follow, which serve, however, only for criticizing art. Thus one must acquaint oneself with models of beauty, in order to acquire taste thereby.¹⁶

This is not an isolated thought, included only haphazardly in a single lecture: he says in the Dohna-Wundlacken Logic that "fine art needs a model (exemplar), then, but not so science[:]; it needs rules."¹⁷ Similarly, in the Jäsche Logic he says

¹⁵KU 5:232.

¹⁶V-Lo/Wiener 24:812.

¹⁷V-Lo/Dohna 24:696.

that "By virtue of the fact that logic is to be taken as a science *a priori*, or as a doctrine for a canon of the use of the understanding and of reason, it is essentially distinct from *aesthetics*, which as mere *critique of taste* has no canon (law) but only a *norm* (model or standard for passing judgment), which consists in universal agreement."¹⁸ All of this shows, then, that Kant distinguishes rules and models quite consistently, and given his description of the ideal as a model in the *KU*, we should be skeptical, on textual grounds, that it can serve as or otherwise provide a rule of taste.

Second, in the Dohna-Wundlacken Logic, Kant says that "a rule is a concept under which much, a manifold of representations, is contained."¹⁹ Given Kant's contrast between concepts, which "can be common to several things," as he puts it in the *Critique of Pure Reason*, and intuitions, which are "singular," we have reason to believe that the ideal, described as the "representation of an individual being" at *KU* 5:232 cannot be a rule since it is not a concept.²⁰ The argument, in other words, is this: either the ideal of beauty is a rule of taste or it is not, but if it is a rule of taste, then the ideal must be a concept. But it is not a concept; rather, it is a singular representation. So the ideal cannot be a rule.²¹

So it seems, then, that on textual grounds we have reason to think that Kant consistently contrasts rules with models, and that since the ideal of beauty is described as a model, it cannot constitute a rule. Further, if we take rules to be concepts, then the ideal cannot be a rule since it is an individual, rather than a general, representation. This gives us reason, then, to reject any reading according to which Kant's inclusion of the ideal of beauty in §17 contradicts his general line of thought according to which there are no rules of beauty, since the ideal cannot be a rule.

¹⁸Log 9:15.

¹⁹V-Lo/Dohna 24:693.

²⁰KrV A320/B377.

²¹At this point one might reasonably ask the following question: "can't one construct a rule out of this supposedly non-rule thing?" The worry, in other words, can be thought of like this: rules all have the form of, say, commands, such as "do ϕ ," "you ought to ϕ ," or something like that, and so regardless of what one substitutes for ϕ , one then has a rule. This, I take it, is to change the topic of discussion—what I am interested in here is talking about the form of ϕ in the first place, since Kant seems to think that some things which can serve the role of ϕ are rules and some are models, rather than what one can do with ϕ by means of combination with some other concepts. In other words, the worry misunderstands Kant's use of the term "rule," at least in the present discussion; a rule does not have to be a complete proposition, but rather, something which constitutes a complete proposition.

4 Conclusion

So to sum up: in this paper I've attempted to show that Kant's inclusion of the ideal of beauty in §17 of the *Critique of the Power of Judgment* is based on genuine philosophical concerns. I've argued that the ideal is introduced in order to explain how unanimous judgments of beauty in certain objects are possible, which it does by providing a universal standard for certain kinds of judgments of beauty. Second, I've argued that the ideal of beauty cannot be understood to be a rule for beauty, and so its inclusion does not contradict Kant's general thought that there can be no rules for beauty.²²

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²²[Acknowledgments]